

CASE ID: 200811710220

**EPISODE NAME: Dalai Lama Visits France 2008**

2008/11/14 - 2009/10/29

Sender: China (710)

Target: France (220)

Issue: Terminate Support of Non-State Actors (10)

Final Outcome: Total Acquiescence by Target State following sanctions imposition (7)

**Summary:**

On 2008/12/06, French President Nicolas Sarkozy met with the Dalai Lama in Poland.<sup>1</sup> In retaliation, China pulled out of the annual EU-China Summit,<sup>2</sup> canceled senior diplomatic exchanges with France,<sup>3</sup> and froze an order for 150 Airbus planes from France.<sup>4</sup> France acquiesced to the sanctions, and recognized Tibet as Chinese territory.<sup>5</sup>

**Narrative:**

In 2008/12, China targeted France with economic and diplomatic sanctions over French President Nicolas Sarkozy's meeting with the Dalai Lama in Poland on 2008/12/06.<sup>6</sup> The initial onset of the episode began on 2008/11/14, when Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesman Qin Gang issued a statement saying China opposes contact between foreign leaders and the Dalai Lama.<sup>7</sup>

After the French president did not cancel the meeting, China "postponed" a planned December EU-China Summit on 2008/11/25, before the president had met with the spiritual leader.<sup>8</sup> Beijing canceled senior diplomatic exchanges between the two countries scheduled for the following month on 2008/12/7,<sup>9</sup> and froze an order of 150 Airbus planes from France on 2008/11/27 (as

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<sup>1</sup> Reuters. "Sarkozy meets Dalai Lama despite Chinese anger." *France 24*, 6 December 2008.

<https://www.france24.com/en/20081206-sarkozy-meets-dalai-lama-despite-chinese-anger->

<sup>2</sup> Traynor, Ian. "China cancels EU summit over Dalai Lama visit." *The Guardian*, 26 November 2008.

<https://www.theguardian.com/world/2008/nov/27/china-dalai-lama-nicholas-sarkozy>

<sup>3</sup> Zhang, K. "Calculating Bully: Explaining Chinese Coercion." Doctoral dissertation, *Massachusetts Institute of Technology*, 2018. <https://dspace.mit.edu/handle/1721.1/122472>.

<sup>4</sup> "CORRECTED-UPDATE 1-Airbus denies summit row bad for China deals" Reuters, 27, November 2008.

<https://www.reuters.com/article/airbus-china/corrected-update-1-airbus-denies-summit-row-bad-for-china-deals-idUSLR38041220081127>.

<sup>5</sup> Ding, Qingfen. "France Goes Back on China's Shopping List." *China Daily*, 29 October 2009.

[http://www.chinadaily.com.cn/china/2009-10/29/content\\_8865307.htm](http://www.chinadaily.com.cn/china/2009-10/29/content_8865307.htm)

<sup>6</sup> Reuters. "Sarkozy meets Dalai Lama despite Chinese anger." *France 24*, 6 December 2008.

<https://www.france24.com/en/20081206-sarkozy-meets-dalai-lama-despite-chinese-anger->

<sup>7</sup> VOA. "China Warns French President over Meeting with Dalai Lama." *Voice of America*, 14 November 2008.

<https://www.voatibetan.com/a/a-28-2008-11-14-voa2-90304662/1273183.html>

<sup>8</sup> Traynor, Ian. "China cancels EU summit over Dalai Lama visit." *The Guardian*, 26 November 2008.

<https://www.theguardian.com/world/2008/nov/27/china-dalai-lama-nicholas-sarkozy>

<sup>9</sup> "China condemns Sarkozy meeting with Dalai Lama" Reuters, 7 December, 2008.

<https://www.reuters.com/article/world/us/china-condemns-sarkozy-meeting-with-dalai-lama-idUSL7471064>

announced by Airbus).<sup>10</sup> Additionally, two Chinese trade delegations quickly crossed France off of their travel agendas, and the first delegation alone signed \$15 billion USD worth of trade deals in other European countries.<sup>11 12</sup>

The episode ended 2009/10/29 with considerable diplomatic efforts towards reconciliation.<sup>13</sup> Paris issued a statement recognizing Tibet as an integral part of China's territory.<sup>14</sup> A Chinese trade delegation soon landed in Paris.<sup>15</sup>

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<sup>10</sup> "CORRECTED-UPDATE 1-Airbus denies summit row bad for China deals" *Reuters*, 27, November 2008. <https://www.reuters.com/article/airbus-china/corrected-update-1-airbus-denies-summit-row-bad-for-china-deals-idUSLR38041220081127>.

<sup>11</sup> Zhang, K. "Calculating Bully: Explaining Chinese Coercion." Doctoral dissertation, *Massachusetts Institute of Technology*, 2018. <https://dspace.mit.edu/handle/1721.1/122472>.

<sup>12</sup> Reilly, James. China's Economic Statecraft: Turning Wealth into Power. *Lowy Institute*, 2013. [https://www.lowyinstitute.org/sites/default/files/reilly\\_chinas\\_economic\\_statecraft\\_web.pdf](https://www.lowyinstitute.org/sites/default/files/reilly_chinas_economic_statecraft_web.pdf).

<sup>13</sup> Ding, Qingfen. "France Goes Back on China's Shopping List." *China Daily*, 29 October 2009. [http://www.chinadaily.com.cn/china/2009-10/29/content\\_8865307.htm](http://www.chinadaily.com.cn/china/2009-10/29/content_8865307.htm).

<sup>14</sup> Ibid.

<sup>15</sup> Ibid.